transportation system and inequality. He adds: 'Children in India are naked. They piss on the streets'. And then somewhat soothingly (or perhaps snidely) he adds: 'but all Indians have inner peace'.[50] A Chinese interlocutor who has been to India tells Patil that before his trip his friends wondered if India was near Africa and had black people. The head of a Chinese consultancy company that produces a report on India shares the response of Chinese interviewees: 'They don't think India has good leadership. They don't think India is rising . . . India is not a Buddhist nation . . . India is another world. Another planet.'[51] In Nanjing, Patil finds that 'Chinese cultural interest in India is limited to movies and fashion' and little beyond.[52]

This popular level of ignorance–disdain is evident among people who should know better. Foreign Minister Wang Yi – the same urbane Wang Yi who negotiated the five-point troop disengagement agreement with External Affairs Minister Subrahmanyam Jaishankar in Moscow in September 2020 – characterizes India as a 'tribal democracy' whose future was uncertain. The future of Indian democracy might well be uncertain, but to describe it as tribal was clearly intended to demean and hurt.[53] Patil is repeatedly asked why the Indian media is so hostile to China and why the Indian government does not rein it in – as if the Chinese elite, which avidly follows the processes of American democracy, is unaware that governments in open societies may be both legally unable and morally unwilling to control journalists.

There is ignorance and disdain too of India's economic capabilities. At a meeting in Changzhou, in the midst of senior company executives from blue-chip Indian companies, a local trade official expresses surprise: 'Manufacturing in India? We have only heard of Indian IT [information technology].' As the meeting progresses, Patil notices that the local officials have left and other attendees are in 'deep sleep . . . mouths agape, in danger of sliding to the carpet'. Patil notes that this is typical of meetings with visiting Indian business delegations: 'The snooze button was pressed in business seminars everywhere I shadowed India in China.'[54] Even Indian IT is largely unknown and ignored. In other areas where India has strengths –